

CHAPTER 7: NEW COUNCIL HEAD. NEW RULES.

Battle day came too soon for Catria, as she really didn't feel ready. After all, she'd only been a war mage for a week. Yet, she walked into the arena with her team.

The arena had a large wall around the battlefield, then the seats sloped up, stadium style, then each team had a platform that was flat and went out to the arena wall behind it. Every team was assigned a platform. Catria went to the Terrian platform with her team.

She looked down at the end of the stadium, across from where York would run the event. Cruia was there. It only took a moment to find Erik with them. He looked as handsome as always. Would she get in trouble if she went over and talked to him? Generally war mages didn't, as they were opponents, but Terrian and Cruia never fought.

"Technically, you can go talk to him," Hrod suddenly informed her.

She startled a bit and turned to him. "That obvious?"

“Yes,” he answered. “Technically, it’s allowed, but I wouldn’t advise it. It may look like we are working with them on something, and with Xena just going missing, it could seem suspicious.”

“This has nothing to do with Xena,” Catria defended. “It has more to do with the soul quests.”

Hrod put his hand on her shoulder. “Don’t worry. I’ll make sure you get to talk to him after the fights.”

They didn’t talk more because York called for everyone’s attention. “Welcome!” he began. “Today is battle day, but before we start the battles, I want to introduce myself. Most of you know me as the councilman from Aschelle, but with the death of Carlin, I am now the new head of the council. As always, with the change of leaders, there will be some changes of rules.”

Catria stiffened, unsure if that was going to be good or bad.

York continued, “This war has been going a very long time. Where it is great that we have civilized war so there are very few deaths and made it so the fae cannot break the barrier and attack us, this is still war, and it is a war that does not have a foreseeable end. Thus, most rules will remain the same. Bloodshed outside of the arena is punishable by death. Accusations are to be fought in the arena. And battles are to be submitted to the counsel before battle day. Yet, a few changes are needed.

“Right now, there is no penalty for a team that attacks and loses. With nothing to lose, attacks will be made over

frivolous things. Thus, the new rule is that if a team attacks and loses, the team captain will receive a beating done by a lesser war mage.”

Gasps came from the crowd.

“Do not worry,” York assured them, quieting them down. “This is for peace. Yes, it is barbaric, but so is war, and this will discourage many attacks.” He took a breath before continuing, “Another rule change will be that where most battles must be submitted before battle day, if there is reason for a sudden attack, it can be issued during the battles, and I will decide if it’s approved.”

There was murmuring through the crowd, with the people unsure whether that was a good idea or not.

York calmed them and gave his final change for the day. “There is also a new rule that if the stakes are high, then war mages may request the right to fight past their gems going dark. I’ve seen too many times people lose an important battle when they would have kept fighting if allowed. Yes, it may mean more blood or death, but still, the losses will be insignificant compared to the old ways of bloody battle.”

Murmurs again went through the crowd with people wondering if this was an improvement or horrific.

Some people from Ramere started chanting, “We want blood! We want blood!” as if the arena was a game.

York again quieted the crowd. He explained that the lesser war mages would continue to keep peace outside of the arena, but that he was expanding them greatly, as

there had been few, and many people didn't even know of them. He assured the crowd the lesser war mages were for their own protection and not to be feared.

After announcing the changes, he announced the battles. "First, Ascelle is attacking Terrian for stealing a crown jewel. Apparently, some Terrian coins were dropped in the crime, so they know who to blame."

"That's ridiculous!" Rhys argued. "Anyone could have left a Terrian coin there. We trade with many cities."

"The attack stands," York insisted. "If you wish to contest it, do so by winning the fight."

Rhys didn't argue more. If York was anything like Carlin, if he argued, he'd take a beating.

York continued, "After that fight, there will be a fight between Ramere and Alfir. Ramere is attacking for fifty magical gemstones. Then, the final fight will be Phyrn against Terrian. They are fighting to get Bruis and Xena back."

"We don't have Xena!" Rhys called out, obviously upset.

"The attack stands," York insisted.

"But we have two fights today," Rhys countered.

"You will not argue," York threatened.

Rhys became instantly silent, knowing he could be beaten.

York continued, "The first fight for the return of the

crown jewels is four on four. Each side, choose your mages.”

Aschelle took the field quickly. The terrain in the area changed often. No one was sure how, but it was different all the time. This time, there was a large grassy field with some small trees near the end where York sat, a small pool of water on the other end, and boulders on each side.

Rhys looked over at his team. He had to fight. The team captain always had to fight if he could. “Hrod, Sean, and Flynn, you are with me.”

The captain of team Aschelle announced, “Quex the Unstoppable, Freya Flashdaggers, Lorelay the Queen, and I, Aiden the Invincible, are ready to fight.”

Rhys shook his head. Aschelle was so pompous and always had to announce themselves as if they were royalty, even giving themselves titles like “unstoppable” and “invincible.”

Rhys simply announced, “Team Terrian reporting.”

He gathered Hrod, Sean, and Flynn, and quickly advised, “I’ve got Aiden. Hrod fight Quex. Flynn, you have Freya, and Sean, fight Lorelay. Have each other’s backs too.”

There wasn’t time to plan, nor was there much reason to give a great deal of instruction, as Aschelle attacked Terrian often.

Before the battle started, Rhys asked for permission to speak, and York granted it.

Rhys braced for the answer before asking, “What happens if we lose? We didn’t steal the jewels, so we cannot return them.”

York glared down at him. “Then you will pay with blood.”

“A beating?” Rhys asked, not sure he wanted to know the answer.

“No,” York corrected. “If you cannot pay for the stolen items, then you, as team captain will be turned over to Aschelle.”

Everyone gasped. That had never been done before.

York quieted the crowd and explained, “There must be harsh penalties for thievery. There has been a rash of thefts of very important items. It must stop, and to do so, war mages must know they cannot use their power to steal, and that there will be high costs.” He then smiled an eerie smile. “But I give you permission to fight past your gem going dark.”

“But...” Rhys started to argue.

York cut him off. “The decision is made. The battle may begin.”

Rhys drew his weapon, knowing he might be about to die.